

CERTIFICATE COMPLEXITY OF UNIFORM DESCENT FOR THE $3x + 1$ PROBLEM

HIKARU WAKAURA

ABSTRACT. We formalize the most natural proof strategy for the $3x + 1$ (Collatz) problem — partition the positive integers into congruence classes and certify uniform descent on each class by an affine identity — as a proof system of *dyadic affine descent certificates*, and we prove quantitative lower bounds on its complexity. Let $c(k)$ denote the number of residues mod 2^k whose length- k parity vector satisfies $3^{e_j} > 2^j$ for every prefix (“climbing classes”). We prove: (i) every correct certificate system contains, for every k , at least $c(k)$ certificates of dyadic depth exceeding k — in particular no finite system exists — and the bound is robust: certificates certifying descent at a variable stopping time over arbitrary finite unions of congruence classes (any eventually periodic scope) collapse to the same canonical frontier and obey the same count; (ii) the non-asymptotic sandwich $\binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil} / k \leq c(k) \leq (k+1) \binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil}$ with $\theta = \log_3 2$, hence the certificate growth rate is exactly $\gamma = H(\theta) = 0.949955\dots$, the binary entropy of θ ; (iii) the “frontier language” of climbing words is not regular; (iv) the climbing walk is driven by the Sturmian word of slope θ , and its block transfer matrices obey the standard-word recursion $B_{n+1} = B_n^{a_{n+1}} B_{n-1}$ governed by the continued fraction of $\log_2 3$. As an unconditional byproduct we show that the number of potential counterexamples up to N — integers whose orbit never descends below its starting point — is $O(N^{H(\theta)+o(1)}) = O(N^{0.950})$, the same entropy exponent. The core arithmetic lemma (classes $-1 \bmod 2^m$ climb for $m-1$ steps with unit 2-adic valuations) is machine-verified in Lean 4. We emphasize that the density statement underlying (ii) is classical (Terras 1976, Everett 1977); our contribution is the *uniform lower bound against arbitrary certificate systems*, the exact non-asymptotic constants, and the Sturmian/automatic-structure analysis. As complements we prove two local obstructions: no bounded function $\psi(n \bmod 2^d)$ makes $\log_2 n + \psi$ a one-step Lyapunov function, and every finite-window constraint family valid on non-descending orbit segments is realized by genuine integer segments, so finite-window hierarchies cannot exclude climbing statistics.

1. INTRODUCTION

The $3x + 1$ problem (Collatz conjecture) asserts that iterating $C(n) = n/2$ for even n and $C(n) = 3n + 1$ for odd n eventually reaches 1 from every positive integer. Despite its elementary statement, the problem has resisted every known technique; see the surveys of Lagarias [3, 4] for its history. Verified convergence now extends to all $n < 2^{68}$ [6], density-one convergence has been known since Terras [1] and Everett [2], and Tao [5] proved that almost all orbits (in logarithmic density) attain almost bounded values.

Faced with such a problem, the strategy that nearly every newcomer — and many published attempts — adopt is the same folk recipe: split the integers into congruence classes mod 2^k , prove on each class an affine identity forcing descent below the starting point, and conclude by strong induction. The recipe succeeds on a set of classes of density approaching 1, and this is precisely the content of the classical density theorems. However, the recipe never seems to terminate: no matter how deep the case analysis is pushed, a residue of unresolved classes survives, and it has

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remained unquantified *whether this is an artifact of particular implementations or a provable property of the strategy itself*.

Here we prove that it is a provable property of the strategy, and we determine its exact cost. We formalize the recipe as a proof system of *dyadic affine descent certificates* (Definition 3.1), flexible enough to cover finite exceptional sets, refinements by odd moduli, and arbitrary mixtures of depths, and we establish the following.

- (i) *A counting lower bound against all systems* (Theorem A): every correct certificate system contains, for every k , at least $c(k)$ certificates of dyadic depth exceeding k , where $c(k)$ is the number of *climbing classes* mod 2^k . In particular no finite certificate system exists, and the depth distribution of any correct system has exponentially heavy tails at every scale. The bound is robust (Theorem A'): allowing each certificate to certify descent at a *variable* stopping time, over a *disjunction* of congruence classes of arbitrary moduli, changes nothing — adaptive stopping collapses to the canonical first-descent time, and each constituent class can serve at most one climbing class.
- (ii) *The exact growth rate* (Theorem B): the non-asymptotic sandwich $\binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil} / k \leq c(k) \leq (k+1) \binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil}$, $\theta = \log_3 2$, whence $\gamma = \lim_k \frac{1}{k} \log_2 c(k) = H(\theta) = 0.9499555272 \dots$. The lower bound rests on an elementary rotation lemma of independent interest.
- (iii) *Fine structure* (Theorems C–E): the climbing condition factorizes over the Sturmian word of slope θ ; block transfer matrices obey the standard-word recursion governed by the continued fraction of $\log_2 3$; and the language of climbing words is not regular, so the certificate frontier admits no finite-automaton compression.
- (iv) *Machine verification*: the core arithmetic lemma — the classes $-1 \bmod 2^m$ climb monotonically for $m-1$ steps with unit 2-adic valuations — is verified in Lean 4 from the standard axioms alone (Section 10).
- (v) *A verified computational artifact*: a depth-20 certificate system (4404 certificates, exact cover of $\mathbb{N} \setminus \{1\}$ up to the climbing classes, density 97.39%) checked by an independent symbolic verifier.
- (vi) *Local obstructions* (Theorems F–G): no bounded syndrome correction $\psi(n \bmod 2^d)$ makes $\log_2 n + \psi$ a one-step Lyapunov function, and finite-window constraint hierarchies cannot exclude climbing statistics, because the all-ones statistics are realized by genuine integer orbit segments at every window length.
- (vii) *A power-saving counterexample count* (Corollary 6.5): unconditionally, the number of $n \leq N$ whose orbit never descends below n is at most $N^{H(\theta)+o(1)}$ — elementary counting gives exponent $1 - \theta(1 - H(\theta)) = 0.9684$, and the effective irrationality measure of $\log_2 3$ improves it to the certificate growth rate $H(\theta) = 0.9500$ itself.

We stress an explicit non-claim. The density exponent $1 - H(\theta)$ of the unresolved classes is classical: it is implicit in Terras’s stopping time distribution [1] and appears in the survey literature [3, 16, 11]. What we claim as new is the *proof-complexity* statement: the transfer of the count from one greedy tree to *all* correct certificate systems (Theorem A), the two-sided non-asymptotic constants and the elementary proof of the exact rate (Theorem B), the Sturmian and automata-theoretic analysis of the frontier (Theorems C–E), the machine-verified core, and the verified depth-20 artifact. In the language of proof complexity, Theorems A–B are a lower bound for a natural, restricted proof system for the $3x+1$ problem, in the spirit of lower bounds for resolution or bounded-depth systems, and they rigorously prune a region of the strategy space in which a large fraction of amateur and computer-assisted attempts operate.

Related recent work. The parity-vector viewpoint has seen recent activity close to our tools: Rozier and Terracol [17] study the *paradoxical* orbit segments (affine coefficient below one, yet no descent) which are exactly the exceptional integers of our collapse lemma; Niu [18]

enumerates paradoxical windows in closed form and observes their continued-fraction structure; and Fernández and Ibáñez [19] prove that Christoffel words are extremal for a cycle functional. We indicate the points of contact as they arise (Remarks 6.6 and 8.2); the proof-system lower bounds and the counting bound proved here do not appear in these works.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 fixes notation and proves the Terras bijection in the form we need. Section 3 defines certificates and systems. Section 4 proves the core lemmas, Section 5 the counting theorem, Section 6 its extension to disjunctive and adaptive systems, and Section 7 the exact growth rate. Section 8 develops the Sturmian structure, Section 9 the local obstructions, Section 10 describes the verified artifacts, and Section 11 delimits what is *not* blocked by these results. An appendix reproduces, for completeness, the standard cycle bound in the form used here.

2. PRELIMINARIES: THE COMPRESSED MAP AND PARITY VECTORS

Throughout, T denotes the *compressed* Collatz map on the positive integers,

$$T(n) = \begin{cases} n/2, & n \text{ even}, \\ (3n+1)/2, & n \text{ odd}, \end{cases}$$

introduced by Terras [1]. For odd n one has $C^2(n) = T(n)$, and since $3n+1 > n$, the orbit of n under C descends below n if and only if the orbit under T does; all our statements therefore transfer to the standard map by this time change. We write $\theta = \log_3 2 = 0.6309297536\dots$ and $H(x) = -x \log_2 x - (1-x) \log_2 (1-x)$ for the binary entropy.

For $n \geq 1$ and $j \geq 0$ let $b_j(n) = T^j(n) \bmod 2$ be the *parity vector* of the orbit, and $e_j(n) = b_0(n) + \dots + b_{j-1}(n)$ the number of odd steps among the first j .

Lemma 2.1 (affine form and Terras bijection). *For every $k \geq 0$ and every residue $r \bmod 2^k$:*

- (a) *the parities $b_0, \dots, b_{k-1}$ are constant on the class $\{n \equiv r \pmod{2^k}\}$; write $e_j = e_j(r)$ for the resulting prefix counts;*
- (b) *there are integers $\beta_j \geq 0$ ($0 \leq j \leq k$), depending only on r , with*

$$T^j(n) = \frac{3^{e_j} n + \beta_j}{2^j} \quad (n \equiv r \bmod 2^k, \ 0 \leq j \leq k),$$

where $\beta_0 = 0$ and $\beta_{j+1} = 3\beta_j + 2^j$ if $b_j = 1$, $\beta_{j+1} = \beta_j$ if $b_j = 0$; moreover $\beta_j \leq 3^j$;

- (c) *the map $r \mapsto (b_0, \dots, b_{k-1})$ is a bijection from $\mathbb{Z}/2^k\mathbb{Z}$ onto $\{0, 1\}^k$.*

Proof. Induction on k , all three claims jointly. For $k = 0$ there is nothing to prove. Assume the claims for k and fix a class $r \bmod 2^k$, with affine form $T^k(n) = (3^{e_k} n + \beta_k)/2^k$. If n and $n' = n + 2^k$ are the two lifts of $r \bmod 2^{k+1}$, then $T^k(n') - T^k(n) = 3^{e_k} \cdot 2^k / 2^k = 3^{e_k}$, which is odd. Hence b_k is constant on each class $\bmod 2^{k+1}$ and takes different values on the two lifts of each class $\bmod 2^k$; this proves (a) and (c) at level $k+1$. For (b), if $b_k = 0$ then $T^{k+1}(n) = T^k(n)/2 = (3^{e_k} n + \beta_k)/2^{k+1}$; if $b_k = 1$ then $T^{k+1}(n) = (3T^k(n) + 1)/2 = (3^{e_k+1} n + 3\beta_k + 2^k)/2^{k+1}$. The update rules and $\beta_{j+1} \leq 3\beta_j + 2^j \leq 3 \cdot 3^j$ give $\beta_j \leq 3^j$ by induction. $\square$

3. CERTIFICATES AND SYSTEMS

Definition 3.1 (dyadic affine descent certificate). A *certificate* is a tuple (r, k, e, β, E) where $k \geq 1$, r is a residue $\bmod 2^k$ whose parity vector has $e = e_k(r)$ odd steps and affine constant $\beta = \beta_k(r)$ as in Lemma 2.1, E is a finite set, and the *descent condition*

$$T^k(n) < n \quad \text{for all } n \in \mathcal{C}, \quad \mathcal{C} = \{n \geq 1 : n \equiv r \bmod 2^k\} \setminus E,$$

holds. More generally we allow the certificate to be restricted to a class $\mathcal{C}' \subseteq \mathcal{C}$ defined by an additional congruence to an odd modulus. In all cases the *dyadic atom* of the certificate is the class $r \bmod 2^k$ in which it lives, and k is its *dyadic depth*.

A *certificate system* S is a finite or infinite family of certificates, together with a finite set D of directly verified integers, such that the union of the certificate classes and D covers $\mathbb{N} \setminus \{1, 2\}$.

A certificate system is exactly what is needed to run the folk proof: if every $n \geq 3$ lies in some certified class (or in D , whose orbits are checked to reach 1 directly), strong induction on n proves the conjecture, provided the exceptional sets are also checked. The point of this paper is that correct systems exist — we exhibit a verified one in Section 10 — but that all of them are infinite, with quantified depth inflation.

4. CLIMBING CLASSES AND THE CORE LEMMAS

Definition 4.1. A residue $r \bmod 2^k$ (equivalently, by Lemma 2.1(c), its parity vector) is *climbing* if $3^{e_j} > 2^j$ for every $1 \leq j \leq k$; equivalently $e_j > \theta j$ for all $j \leq k$. Let $c(k)$ denote the number of climbing residues $\bmod 2^k$, and let $L \subseteq \{0, 1\}^*$ be the language of climbing words.

The first lemma shows that climbing classes exist in abundance — indeed the class $-1 \bmod 2^m$ climbs for $m - 1$ full steps, realizing the extremal growth rate $(3/2)^{m-1}$.

Lemma 4.2 (climb lemma; machine-verified). *Let $m \geq 1$, $t \geq 1$ and $n = 2^m t - 1$. Define $n_j = 3^j 2^{m-j} t - 1$ for $0 \leq j \leq m - 1$, so $n_0 = n$. Then for $0 \leq j \leq m - 2$: n_j is odd, $T(n_j) = n_{j+1}$, and $n_{j+1} > n_j$. In particular the first $m - 1$ steps of the orbit of n are all odd steps, the orbit is strictly increasing along them, and $n_j \equiv -1 \pmod{2^{m-j}}$ for all $j \leq m - 1$.*

Proof. For $j \leq m - 1$ the number $3^j 2^{m-j} t$ is even (as $m - j \geq 1$), so n_j is odd. For $j \leq m - 2$,

$$T(n_j) = \frac{3n_j + 1}{2} = \frac{3^{j+1} 2^{m-j} t - 2}{2} = 3^{j+1} 2^{m-j-1} t - 1 = n_{j+1},$$

and $T(n) = (3n + 1)/2 > n$ holds for every positive n . The congruence is read off the formula. This lemma is machine-verified in Lean 4 (Section 10). $\square$

Corollary 4.3. *For every $k \geq 1$ the class $-1 \bmod 2^k$ is climbing; hence $c(k) \geq 1$.*

Proof. By Lemma 4.2 (with $m = k$), the values $n_0, \dots, n_{k-1}$ are all odd, so the parity vector of the class is all-ones: $e_j = j$ and $3^j > 2^j$ for every $j \leq k$. $\square$

Lemma 4.4 (climbing classes admit no certificate). *If $3^e \geq 2^k$ and $\beta \geq 0$, then $(3^e n + \beta)/2^k < n$ holds for no $n \geq 1$. Consequently a certificate of depth k (which certifies descent for all but finitely many n in an infinite class) must have $3^{e_k} < 2^k$, i.e. its dyadic atom is non-climbing at its own depth.*

Proof. $(3^e n + \beta)/2^k \geq n \cdot 3^e/2^k \geq n$. $\square$

Lemma 4.5 (prefix closedness and locality). (a) *Climbing is prefix-closed: if $r \bmod 2^k$ is climbing and $k' \leq k$, then the reduction $r \bmod 2^{k'}$ is climbing.*

(b) *A certificate of dyadic depth $k' \leq k$ covers no element of any climbing class $\bmod 2^k$.*

(c) *A certificate of dyadic depth $k'' > k$ has its atom contained in exactly one class $\bmod 2^k$.*

Proof. (a) is immediate from Definition 4.1, since the conditions for $j \leq k'$ are a subset of those for $j \leq k$ and, by Lemma 2.1, the parity prefix of the reduced class is the prefix of the parity vector. For (b): by Lemma 4.4 the certificate's atom $r' \bmod 2^{k'}$ satisfies $3^{e_{k'}} < 2^{k'}$, so it is not climbing at depth k' ; but by (a) the reduction $\bmod 2^{k'}$ of any climbing class $\bmod 2^k$ is climbing at depth k' ; hence the two classes $\bmod 2^{k'}$ are distinct and therefore disjoint. (c) is trivial. $\square$

5. THE COUNTING THEOREM

Theorem A (certificate-counting lower bound). Let S be any correct certificate system. Then for every $k \geq 1$, S contains at least $c(k)$ certificates of dyadic depth exceeding k . In particular:

- (a) no finite certificate system exists;
- (b) with Theorem B below, the system S contains at least $2^{H(\theta)k - O(\log k)}$ certificates of depth $> k$, for every k : the depth distribution of every correct system has exponentially heavy tails at every scale.

Proof. Fix k and a climbing class $\mathcal{K} \bmod 2^k$. The class contains infinitely many integers and only finitely many lie in the directly verified set D , so some $n \in \mathcal{K}$ is covered by a certificate of S . By Lemma 4.5(b), no certificate of depth $\leq k$ covers any element of $\mathcal{K}$; hence that certificate has depth $> k$. By Lemma 4.5(c), a certificate of depth $> k$ meets exactly one class $\bmod 2^k$, so certificates assigned in this way to distinct climbing classes are distinct. There are $c(k)$ climbing classes, giving $c(k)$ distinct certificates of depth $> k$. Claim (a) follows since $c(k) \geq 1$ for all k (Corollary 4.3) and a finite system has a maximal depth. Claim (b) follows from the lower bound in Theorem B, since $kH(\lceil \theta k \rceil / k) = kH(\theta) + O(1)$ and $\binom{k}{e} \geq 2^{kH(e/k)/(k+1)}$. $\square$

Remark 5.1. The proof uses nothing about the internal structure of the certificates beyond Lemmas 4.4 and 4.5; in particular it applies verbatim to systems mixing arbitrary depths, refining by odd moduli, and discarding arbitrary finite exceptional sets. Systems whose members certify descent for a *disjunction* of congruence classes under an *adaptive* stopping rule are not covered by the statement as given; Section 6 extends the bound to exactly that setting.

6. ROBUSTNESS: DISJUNCTIONS AND ADAPTIVE STOPPING

The folk strategy admits two natural liberalizations that Definition 3.1 does not cover: a single certificate might claim descent for a *union* of congruence classes, and it might allow the descent time to *vary with n* instead of being the fixed depth of an affine identity. This section shows that neither liberalization, nor both together, weakens the counting bound: adaptive stopping collapses to a canonical stopping time on every congruence class, and each constituent class of a valid disjunction can serve at most one climbing class.

Definition 6.1 (adaptive disjunctive certificate). An *adaptive disjunctive certificate* is a tuple (U, K, E) where $U = C_1 \cup \dots \cup C_w$ is a finite union of congruence classes $C_t = \{n \geq 1 : n \equiv r_t \bmod 2^{d_t} q_t\}$ with q_t odd (we call d_t the *dyadic depth* of the constituent C_t , and w the *width*), $K \geq 1$ is the *horizon*, E is finite, and the claim

$$\forall n \in U \setminus E \quad \exists j \leq K : T^j(n) < n$$

is true. An *adaptive system* is a countable family of such certificates, plus a finite directly verified set D , with $\bigcup_i (U_i \setminus E_i) \cup D \supseteq \mathbb{N} \setminus \{1, 2\}$. Since every eventually periodic subset of $\mathbb{N}$ is, up to a finite set, a finite union of congruence classes, this notion covers every certificate whose scope is defined by congruence information of any modulus — including odd moduli such as powers of 3.

Lemma 6.2 (adaptive collapse). Fix a class $r \bmod 2^K$ with prefix counts e_j (Lemma 2.1) and let $j_1 = \min\{j \leq K : 3^{e_j} < 2^j\}$ (with $j_1 = \infty$ if the class is climbing at depth K). Then for every $n \equiv r \pmod{2^K}$:

- (a) $T^j(n) > n$ for every $j \leq K$ with $3^{e_j} > 2^j$ — with no condition on n ; this holds in particular for every $j < j_1$, and if $j_1 = \infty$ then no $n \geq 1$ in the class descends below itself within K steps;

(b) if $j_1 \leq K$ and $n > 3^{j_1}$ then $T^{j_1}(n) < n$.

Consequently, for $n > 3^K$ the events “ $T^j(n) < n$ for some $j \leq K$ ” and “ $j_1 \leq K$ ” coincide, and the first descent time equals j_1 exactly: on every congruence class, an adaptive stopping time collapses to the canonical first-descent time. (This is the elementary, horizon-bounded direction of Terras’s coefficient stopping time analysis [1].)

Proof. (a) $T^j(n) = (3^{e_j}n + \beta_j)/2^j \geq 3^{e_j}n/2^j > n$ whenever $3^{e_j} > 2^j$, with no condition on n ; for $j < j_1$ this inequality holds by minimality of j_1 . (b) Descent at j_1 is $n(2^{j_1} - 3^{e_{j_1}}) > \beta_{j_1}$; the left side is $\geq n$ (the bracket is a positive integer) and $\beta_{j_1} \leq 3^{j_1}$ by Lemma 2.1(b). The consequence follows since steps $j < j_1$ never descend by (a) and step j_1 descends by (b). $\square$

Lemma 6.3 (persistence of climbing). *If $r \bmod 2^k$ is climbing, its extension appending the parity 1 is a climbing class mod 2^{k+1} . Hence $c(k+1) \geq c(k)$; every climbing class mod 2^k contains a climbing class mod 2^K for every $K \geq k$; and the intersection of a climbing class with any congruence class to an odd modulus is infinite.*

Proof. Prefix conditions up to k are unchanged, and at $k+1$: $3^{e_{k+1}} = 3 \cdot 3^{e_k} > 3 \cdot 2^k > 2^{k+1}$. Iterating gives the second claim; the third is the Chinese remainder theorem. $\square$

Theorem A’ (robustness under disjunction and adaptive stopping). Let S be any correct adaptive system. Then:

- (a) every constituent class of every certificate of S is non-climbing at its own dyadic depth;
- (b) for every $k \geq 1$, at least $c(k)$ constituent classes across S have dyadic depth exceeding k , and every certificate covering an element of a climbing class mod 2^k has horizon exceeding k . If every certificate of S has width at most w , then S contains at least $c(k)/w$ certificates whose horizon and dyadic depth exceed k ;
- (c) (packaging invariance) for every valid (U, K, E) ,

$$U \setminus (E \cup [1, 3^K]) \subseteq D(K) := \bigcup \{ \text{classes mod } 2^K \text{ with } j_1 \leq K \},$$

and conversely $D(K)$ is covered by the canonical uniform tree of first-descent certificates of depth $\leq K$ with exceptions in $[1, 3^K]$. Every adaptive disjunctive system is therefore, up to finite sets, a repackaging of the canonical first-descent tree.

Proof. (a) Suppose the constituent C_t (dyadic depth d , odd modulus q_t , inside a certificate of horizon K) is climbing at depth d . By Lemma 6.3 there is a climbing class mod $2^{\max(d, K)}$ inside its dyadic class, and its intersection with the congruence condition mod q_t is infinite; every n in that intersection satisfies $T^j(n) > n$ for all $j \leq K$ by Lemma 6.2(a). All but finitely many of these n avoid E , so the certificate’s claim is false.

(b) Fix a climbing class $\mathcal{K}$ mod 2^k and pick $n \in \mathcal{K} \setminus D$ covered by some certificate, say $n \in C_t \setminus E$. By (a) the class C_t has a first non-climbing prefix $j_1 \leq d_t$. Since $n \in \mathcal{K}$, the parity prefix of n is climbing at every depth $\leq k$; since $n \in C_t$, its prefix at depth j_1 is that of C_t , which is non-climbing. Hence $j_1 > k$, so $d_t \geq j_1 > k$, and the dyadic class of C_t reduces mod 2^k to the single class $\mathcal{K}$. Distinct climbing classes therefore meet distinct constituent classes, giving at least $c(k)$ constituents of dyadic depth $> k$. For the horizon: the prefixes of n at depths $\leq k$ are climbing, so $T^j(n) > n$ for all $j \leq k$ (Lemma 6.2(a)), and the certified descent time of n exceeds k ; hence $K > k$. The width bound is immediate.

(c) For $n \in U \setminus E$ with $n > 3^K$, the claim provides a descent within K steps, and Lemma 6.2 shows this forces $j_1(n \bmod 2^K) \leq K$, i.e. $n \in D(K)$. Conversely each class mod 2^K with $j_1 \leq K$ is certified by the affine certificate of depth j_1 at its first-descent prefix, whose exceptional set is contained in $[1, 3^{j_1}]$ by Lemma 6.2(b). $\square$

Remark 6.4 (numerical verification). The collapse of Lemma 6.2 was checked exhaustively for all $2 \leq n \leq 2^{20}$ at horizon $K = 12$ (no violations; in this range no exceptional stragglers below the 3^{j_1} bound occurred at all), the monotonicity $c(k+1) \geq c(k)$ was confirmed to $k = 20$ with the anchor $c(20) = 27328$ of Section 10, and invalidity witnesses for climbing constituents with odd moduli $q \in \{5, 7, 11\}$ were confirmed at horizons up to 80.

The collapse lemma has a further unconditional consequence: a power-saving upper bound on the number of potential counterexamples to the conjecture itself.

Corollary 6.5 (counting potential counterexamples). *Let $\mathcal{E} = \{n > 1 : T^j(n) \geq n \text{ for all } j \geq 1\}$, the set of integers whose orbit never descends below its starting point. (The least element of any divergent orbit and of any nontrivial cycle lies in $\mathcal{E}$, and the conjecture is equivalent to $\mathcal{E} = \emptyset$.) Then:*

- (a) *elementarily, $|\mathcal{E} \cap [1, N]| \leq C(\log_2 N)^2 N^{1-\theta(1-H(\theta))}$, with $1-\theta(1-H(\theta)) = 0.968426\dots$;*
- (b) *using the effective irrationality measure $|j \log 2 - e \log 3| > c j^{-13.3}$ of Rhin [9], for effectively large N ,*

$$|\mathcal{E} \cap [1, N]| \leq (\log_2 N) c(\lfloor \log_2 N \rfloor) = N^{H(\theta)+o(1)} = N^{0.94996\dots} ;$$

the counting exponent equals the certificate growth rate γ .

Proof. (a) Let $n \in \mathcal{E} \cap (M, 2M]$ with $M = 2^m$ and set $j = \lfloor \log_3 M \rfloor$, so $n > 3^j$. By Lemma 6.2 the class of $n \bmod 2^j$ is climbing. There are $c(j)$ such classes, each meeting $(M, 2M]$ in exactly 2^{m-j} integers, so $|\mathcal{E} \cap (M, 2M]| \leq c(j)2^{m-j} \leq (j+1)2^{jH(\theta)}2^{m-j}$ by Theorem B; since $j = \lfloor \theta m \rfloor$, this is $\leq (m+1)2M \cdot M^{-\theta(1-H(\theta))}$, and summing over dyadic blocks gives (a).

(b) Suppose $n \in (M, 2M]$ has its first non-climbing prefix at depth $j_1 \leq m$. Failure of descent at j_1 requires $n(2^{j_1} - 3^{e_{j_1}}) \leq \beta_{j_1} \leq 3^{j_1}$. If $3^{e_{j_1}} \leq 2^{j_1-1}$ the gap is at least 2^{j_1-1} ; otherwise $2^{j_1} - 3^{e_{j_1}} = 3^{e_{j_1}}(e^\Lambda - 1) \geq 2^{j_1-1}\Lambda$ with $\Lambda = j_1 \ln 2 - e_{j_1} \ln 3 \geq c j_1^{-13.3}$ [9]. Either way $n \leq 2(3/2)^{j_1} j_1^{13.3}/c$, which is smaller than $2^m < n$ for every $j_1 \leq m$ once $m \geq m_0(c)$, effectively. Hence every $n \in \mathcal{E} \cap (M, 2M]$ is climbing at depth m ; each residue mod 2^m occurs exactly once in $(M, 2M]$, so $|\mathcal{E} \cap (M, 2M]| \leq c(m)$. Summing over dyadic blocks, using that c is non-decreasing (Lemma 6.3), gives (b). $\square$

Remark 6.6. (i) The exceptional integers in the proof of (b) — a non-climbing prefix at depth j_1 , yet no descent there — are precisely the initial terms of the *paradoxical sequences* of Rozier–Terracol [17] (with the window ending at the first non-climbing depth, where the affine coefficient first drops below one). Their remainder bound [17, Thm. 2.4], $\beta_j/2^j \leq (3^q - 2^q)/2^q$ with $q = e_j$, sharpens the envelope of the margin bound $B(j) := \max \beta_j/(2^j - 3^{e_j})$ from $(3/2)^j j^{13.3}$ to $(3/2)^{\theta j} j^{13.3}$ (up to constants), since $q < \theta j$ at a non-climbing depth; and their Theorem 1.3 shows no such integer exists in $(4614, 2.8 \times 10^{19})$. Numerically $B(j) \leq 24$ for all $j \leq 24$, with spikes exactly at the best rational approximations of $\log_2 3$ (e.g. the Pythagorean-comma depth, $2^8/3^5$) — the same continued-fraction structure observed for paradoxical ratios in [18]. (ii) The recent literature enumerates paradoxical *windows* [18] and shows that finiteness of the set of paradoxical sequences implies the conjecture [17, Cor. 3.3]; a power-saving count of the non-descending set $\mathcal{E}$ itself does not appear there, nor anywhere else we could locate. Both bounds are routine consequences of the present framework (and, for (b), of [9]), and we state them with that caveat. (iii) The shadow method is exhausted at the exponent $H(\theta)$: the set of integers in $(M, 2M]$ satisfying all depth- m congruence necessary conditions has exactly $c(m)$ elements, so no argument using congruence shadows alone can lower the exponent further. Pushing the forced-climbing depth to its true limit $\log_{3/2} n$ would require counting climbing residues that are *small as integers* — information not contained in shadows (heuristically that limit exponent is $1 - (1 - H(\theta))/\log_2(3/2) = 0.91445\dots$). (iv) Thematically, (b) ties the two halves of the problem

together: the counterexample count is governed by the certificate entropy, and the enhancement input is the same linear-forms data that governs the cycle bound of Appendix A.

Remark 6.7 (what robustness does and does not say). Theorem A' closes every liberalization of the folk strategy whose certificate scopes are eventually periodic sets — in particular, partitioning by residues modulo powers of 3, or any mixed modulus, buys nothing, and neither does any orbit-adaptive stopping rule. What remains outside its quantification are certificates whose scopes are *not* unions of congruence classes: sets defined by inequalities on orbit values, by unbounded-window parity information, or by genuinely analytic (ensemble) data. Section 11 discusses these exits.

7. THE EXACT GROWTH RATE

Lemma 7.1 (rotation lemma). *Let $b = (b_1, \dots, b_k) \in \{0, 1\}^k$ with $e = \sum_i b_i$ and $e - \theta k > 0$. Then some cyclic rotation of b is climbing, i.e. has all prefix sums $e_j - \theta j$ positive.*

Proof. Set $w_i = b_i - \theta$ and $S_j = w_1 + \dots + w_j$, $S_0 = 0$, so $S_k = e - \theta k > 0$. Since θ is irrational, the values $S_0, \dots, S_{k-1}$ are pairwise distinct (an equality $S_a = S_b$ with $a < b$ would make $\theta = (e_b - e_a)/(b - a)$ rational). Let j^* be the unique index in $\{0, \dots, k-1\}$ at which $\min_{0 \leq j \leq k-1} S_j$ is attained, and consider the rotation $b' = (b_{j^*+1}, \dots, b_k, b_1, \dots, b_{j^*})$. Its prefix sums are

$$S'_i = S_{j^*+i} - S_{j^*} \quad (1 \leq i \leq k - j^*), \quad S'_{k-j^*+i} = S_k - S_{j^*} + S_i \quad (1 \leq i \leq j^*).$$

The first group is positive because S_{j^*} is the strict minimum among $S_0, \dots, S_{k-1}$ and $S_k > S_0 \geq S_{j^*}$; the second group is positive because $S_i \geq S_{j^*}$ and $S_k > 0$. Hence all prefix sums of b' are positive, which is the climbing condition. $\square$

Theorem B (exact growth rate). For every $k \geq 1$, with $\theta = \log_3 2$,

$$\frac{1}{k} \binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil} \leq c(k) \leq (k+1) \binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil}.$$

Consequently $\gamma := \lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1}{k} \log_2 c(k)$ exists and

$$\gamma = H(\theta) = H(\log_3 2) = 0.9499555272 \dots$$

Moreover c is supermultiplicative, $c(k_1 + k_2) \geq c(k_1)c(k_2)$, so the limit also equals $\sup_k \frac{1}{k} \log_2 c(k)$.

Proof. Lower bound. Let $e = \lceil \theta k \rceil$, so $e - \theta k > 0$ (θk is irrational). Partition the $\binom{k}{e}$ words with e ones into classes under cyclic rotation; each class has at most k elements, and by Lemma 7.1 each class contains at least one climbing word. By Lemma 2.1(c) every word is the parity vector of exactly one residue, so $c(k) \geq \binom{k}{e}/k$.

Upper bound. A climbing word satisfies $e_k > \theta k$, so $e_k \geq \lceil \theta k \rceil$. Since $\theta > 1/2$, the binomial coefficients $\binom{k}{e}$ are non-increasing for $e \geq \lceil \theta k \rceil \geq k/2$, whence

$$c(k) \leq \sum_{e \geq \lceil \theta k \rceil} \binom{k}{e} \leq (k+1 - \lceil \theta k \rceil) \binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil} \leq (k+1) \binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil}.$$

Supermultiplicativity. If u is climbing of length k_1 and v climbing of length k_2 , then the concatenation uv is climbing: for $j \leq k_1$ the prefix sums are those of u ; for $j = k_1 + i$ they equal $S_{k_1}^u + S_i^v > 0$. Distinct pairs give distinct concatenations, so $c(k_1 + k_2) \geq c(k_1)c(k_2)$. Fekete's lemma applied to the superadditive sequence $\log_2 c(k)$ (finite since $c(k) \leq 2^k$, and $c(k) \geq 1$ by Corollary 4.3) yields $\lim_k \frac{1}{k} \log_2 c(k) = \sup_k \frac{1}{k} \log_2 c(k)$.

The value. By Stirling, $\frac{1}{k} \log_2 \binom{k}{\lceil \theta k \rceil} \rightarrow H(\theta)$, and the polynomial factors $1/k$, $(k+1)$ do not affect the limit. $\square$

Remark 7.2 (numerical verification). The sandwich was verified computationally for all $k \leq 1600$ against exact values of $c(k)$ computed by dynamic programming over the walk of Theorem C, and the climbing condition was checked against exhaustive enumeration of all 2^k words for $k \leq 16$. The fluctuation $\tilde{b}(k) = \log_2 c(k) - \log_2 \binom{k}{\lfloor \theta k \rfloor}$ stays within the proven window $[-\log_2 k, \log_2(k+1)]$ throughout.

Corollary 7.3 (density; classical in content). *The natural density of the union of climbing classes at depth k is $c(k)/2^k = 2^{-(1-H(\theta))k+o(k)}$, with $1 - H(\theta) = 0.0500444728\dots$; equivalently, the greedy certificate tree of depth k certifies descent on a set of density $1 - c(k)/2^k \rightarrow 1$. This recovers, in certificate form, the density theorems of Terras and Everett [1, 2, 16].*

8. STURMIAN STRUCTURE OF THE FRONTIER

For $j \geq 1$ let

$$\sigma_j = \lfloor (j+1)\theta \rfloor - \lfloor j\theta \rfloor \in \{0, 1\}$$

be the j -th letter of the *characteristic Sturmian word* of slope θ [21, Ch. 2].

Theorem C (Sturmian letter factorization). For a word $(b_1, \dots, b_k)$ define the *excess walk* $d_j = e_j - \lfloor \theta j \rfloor - 1$. Then the word is climbing if and only if $d_j \geq 0$ for all $1 \leq j \leq k$, and the walk updates by

$$d_{j+1} - d_j = b_{j+1} - \sigma_j \in \begin{cases} \{0, +1\}, & \sigma_j = 0, \\ \{-1, 0\}, & \sigma_j = 1. \end{cases}$$

Hence $c(k)$ equals the number of non-negative paths of the σ -driven walk started from the forced first step $b_1 = 1$ (i.e. $d_1 = 0$).

Proof. Since θj is irrational for $j \geq 1$, $e_j > \theta j$ is equivalent to $e_j \geq \lfloor \theta j \rfloor + 1$, i.e. $d_j \geq 0$. The update is immediate from $e_{j+1} = e_j + b_{j+1}$ and the definition of σ_j . At $j = 1$: $\lfloor \theta \rfloor = 0$, so $d_1 = b_1 - 1 \geq 0$ forces $b_1 = 1$. $\square$

For the block structure, write the continued fraction $\theta = [0; a_1, a_2, a_3, \dots] = [0; 1, 1, 1, 2, 2, 3, 1, 5, 2, \dots]$ and let $s_0 = 0$, $s_1 = 1$, $s_{n+1} = s_n^{a_{n+1}} s_{n-1}$ be the associated standard words; their lengths are the continued-fraction denominators $q_n = 1, 1, 2, 3, 8, 19, 65, 84, 485, 1054, \dots$ of θ , and the characteristic word σ is their limit [21, Ch. 2]. Encode the two letter steps of Theorem C as infinite 0–1 transfer matrices acting on the state $d \in \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$, in the row-vector convention:

$$M(0)_{d,d'} = [d' = d] + [d' = d + 1], \quad M(1)_{d,d'} = [d' = d - 1]_{d \geq 1} + [d' = d].$$

Products of k such matrices are banded (bandwidth $\leq k$), so all entries below are finite sums.

Theorem D (standard-word block recursion). Let $B_n = M(\sigma\text{-letters of } s_n)$ be the ordered product of letter matrices along the standard word s_n (row-vector convention: products compose in word order). Then

$$B_{n+1} = B_n^{a_{n+1}} B_{n-1} \quad (n \geq 1),$$

and for every k ,

$$c(k) = \left(e_0^\top M(\sigma_1) M(\sigma_2) \cdots M(\sigma_{k-1}) \right) \mathbf{1},$$

where e_0 is the coordinate vector of the state $d = 0$.

Proof. The map assigning to a finite word the ordered product of its letter matrices is a monoid morphism (in the row-vector convention, concatenation maps to product in the same order), so the matrix recursion is the image of the standard-word recursion $s_{n+1} = s_n^{a_{n+1}} s_{n-1}$. The formula for $c(k)$ is Theorem C: the matrix entry $(M(\sigma_1) \cdots M(\sigma_{k-1}))_{0,d}$ counts the walks from $d_1 = 0$ to $d_k = d$ that stay non-negative, and summing over d counts all climbing words. $\square$

Remark 8.1 (numerics). The identification of σ with the limit of the standard words was checked letter-by-letter to length 1054 ($= q_9$); the matrix recursion was verified exactly on truncation-exact corners and modulo the prime 3000017 for $n \leq 6$; and the matrix-product formula for $c(k)$ was checked against the direct dynamic program for $k \leq 200$. A two-letter statistic captures most of the fluctuation of $\log_2 c(k)$ around $H(\theta)k$: empirically $\mathbb{E}[\Delta\varphi \mid \sigma = 0] = +0.05004 \approx 1 - H(\theta)$ and $\mathbb{E}[\Delta\varphi \mid \sigma = 1] = -0.03022$ explain 82% of the variance, rising to 97.6% at the level of derived-word blocks — the fluctuation of the certificate count is governed by the first two levels of the continued-fraction hierarchy of $\log_2 3$.

Theorem E (non-regularity of the frontier). The language L of climbing words is not regular. More precisely, for $a, b \geq 1$,

$$1^a 0^b \in L \iff b \leq \left\lceil a \frac{1-\theta}{\theta} \right\rceil - 1,$$

and since the right-hand side is unbounded in a , the Myhill–Nerode equivalence has infinitely many classes.

Proof. For the word $1^a 0^b$ the prefix sums are $e_j - \theta j = j(1 - \theta) > 0$ for $j \leq a$, and $e_{a+i} - \theta(a+i) = a - \theta(a+i)$ for $1 \leq i \leq b$, which is positive iff $i < a(1 - \theta)/\theta$; as θ is irrational, equality is impossible, so the condition on b is $b \leq \lceil a(1 - \theta)/\theta \rceil - 1$. Write $\phi(a)$ for this bound; ϕ is unbounded. If $a \neq a'$ with $\phi(a) < \phi(a')$, the word $0^{\phi(a')}$ separates 1^a from $1^{a'}$; hence infinitely many Myhill–Nerode classes, and L is not regular. $\square$

Remark 8.2 (related work). Balanced-word structures have independently surfaced on the cycle side of the problem: Fernández–Ibáñez [19] prove that Christoffel words — the finite relatives of standard Sturmian words — are, up to rotation, the unique maximizers of a cycle functional on binary words of fixed length and weight, yielding bounds on the minimum element of a hypothetical cycle. Their extremal role there and the driving role of the characteristic Sturmian word here (Theorems C–D) are distinct phenomena with a common source: the affine functional $3^e/2^j$ is extremized under balance constraints governed by the continued fraction of $\log_2 3$.

Conjecture 8.3. *The sequence $c(k)$ is not P -recursive (holonomic). (Supporting evidence: an exhaustive search found no polynomial-coefficient recurrence of order ≤ 6 and degree ≤ 6 , with the kernel computations confirmed modulo three independent primes; and the Sturmian driving of Theorem C ties the fine structure of $c(k)$ to the continued fraction of $\log_2 3$, which is not eventually periodic as far as it has been computed.)*

9. LOCAL OBSTRUCTIONS

The counting theorem bounds one specific proof system. It is natural to ask whether small modifications escape it: a bounded “syndrome correction” to the potential $\log_2 n$, or a hierarchy of finite-window constraints meant to exclude the climbing statistics. The following two results close the bounded-memory variants of both ideas; their scope limitations are stated explicitly and discussed in Section 11.

Theorem F (no bounded dyadic one-step Lyapunov function). Let $d \geq 1$, $\psi : \mathbb{Z}/2^d\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, $\varepsilon > 0$, and set $\varphi(n) = \log_2 n + \psi(n \bmod 2^d)$. Then the one-step descent property

$$\varphi(T(n)) \leq \varphi(n) - \varepsilon \quad \text{for all } n > 1$$

fails. In fact it fails on the single class $n \equiv -1 \pmod{2^{d+1}}$: there the syndrome is a fixed point and the step is expanding.

Proof. Let $n = 2^{d+1}t - 1$, $t \geq 1$. Then n is odd, $n \equiv -1 \pmod{2^d}$, and by Lemma 4.2 (with $m = d + 1$) $T(n) = 3 \cdot 2^d t - 1 \equiv -1 \pmod{2^d}$. Hence $\psi(T(n) \bmod 2^d) = \psi(n \bmod 2^d)$ and

$$\varphi(T(n)) - \varphi(n) = \log_2 \frac{3n+1}{2n} > \log_2 \frac{3}{2} > 0,$$

contradicting descent by any $\varepsilon > 0$. $\square$

Remark 9.1 (robustness of the obstruction). Theorem F is stated for the all-ones syndrome because one class suffices, but the obstruction is much fatter: in the natural linear-programming relaxation over the syndrome transition graph, every shift-invariant measure on parity sequences with odd-step frequency $\rho > \theta$ has positive drift $\rho \log_2 3 - 1 > 0$, and these measures form a non-empty compact convex set. Any per-step, bounded-memory dyadic correction thus fails robustly, not by a degenerate coincidence. By contrast, deleting the states with two trailing ones makes the maximum mean cycle negative: an explicit finite Lyapunov function exists for orbits that never visit $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$; compare Corollary 9.3.

Theorem G (cylinder-local realization). Fix a window length $w \geq 1$ and a syndrome depth $d \geq 1$. There exist infinitely many n (namely all $n = 2^{w+d+1}t - 1$, $t \geq 1$) whose first w compressed steps form a strictly increasing orbit segment with all steps odd, unit 2-adic valuations ($v_2(3n_j + 1) = 1$), and constant all-ones syndrome $n_j \equiv -1 \pmod{2^d}$ for $0 \leq j \leq w$. Consequently, any family of constraints on length- w windows of (parities, valuations, depth- d syndromes) that is valid for all non-descending integer orbit segments is satisfied by the all-ones statistics: finite-window constraint hierarchies cannot exclude climbing statistics.

Proof. Apply Lemma 4.2 with $m = w + d + 1$: for $j \leq w$ the values $n_j = 3^j 2^{m-j} t - 1$ satisfy $n_j \equiv -1 \pmod{2^{m-j}}$ and $m - j \geq d + 1$, so all listed statistics of the window coincide with those of the all-ones cylinder, while the segment is a genuine orbit of a positive integer and is strictly increasing (hence non-descending). $\square$

Remark 9.2 (scope). Theorem G is a $\forall w \exists n$ statement: for each window length some integer realizes the climbing statistics. It does not produce a single n realizing them for all w (that would be a divergent orbit). Its force is contrapositive: any proof method whose reach is exhausted by constraints on bounded windows of bounded-depth dyadic data cannot prove the conjecture, since such constraints hold equally in the 2-adic completion, where the all-ones orbit ($-1 \mapsto -1$) exists. Local statistics see only $\mathbb{Z}_2$, not $\mathbb{N}$.

Corollary 9.3 (forced visits to 3 mod 4). *If $n > 3^k$ and $T^j(n) \geq n$ for all $j \leq k$, then the orbit segment visits $\{m \equiv 3 \pmod{4}\}$ at least $(2\theta - 1)k - 1$ times among $j = 0, \dots, k - 1$; the frequency is at least $2\theta - 1 - O(1/k)$, with $2\theta - 1 = 0.2618595\dots$*

Proof. Non-descent through depth k forces the climbing condition $e_j > \theta j$ for all $j \leq k$: if some prefix had $3^{e_j} < 2^j$, then by Lemma 2.1(b) descent $T^j(n) < n$ would hold whenever $n(2^j - 3^{e_j}) > \beta_j$, which is guaranteed by $n > 3^k \geq \beta_j$ since $2^j - 3^{e_j} \geq 1$. An odd m has $T(m)$ odd iff $3m + 1 \equiv 2 \pmod{4}$ iff $m \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$. Thus visits to 3 mod 4 within the window are exactly the adjacent pairs $b_j = b_{j+1} = 1$. A binary word of length k with e ones has at least $e - (k - e + 1) = 2e - k - 1$ such pairs (the ones form at most $k - e + 1$ blocks). With $e \geq \theta k$ this gives $(2\theta - 1)k - 1$. $\square$

10. VERIFIED COMPUTATIONAL ARTIFACTS

10.1. The depth-20 certificate system. A greedy certificate tree of dyadic depth 20 was generated and independently verified. It consists of 4404 certificates whose atoms, together with the $c(20) = 27328$ climbing classes mod 2^{20} , form an exact partition of $\mathbb{Z}/2^{20}\mathbb{Z}$; the certified

classes have natural density $1 - 27328/2^{20} = 97.39\%$, and the single exceptional integer across the entire system is $n = 1$ (the endpoint of the trivial cycle, for which descent is not required). Each certificate is stored as the full tuple $(k, \text{mod}, r, e, \beta, \text{exceptions})$ in a JSON artifact.

The verifier is deliberately independent of the generator: it re-derives the parity vectors and affine data symbolically from scratch (Lemma 2.1), checks exact cover and disjointness of the atoms, re-checks the descent inequality $n(2^k - 3^e) > \beta$ at the minimal element of each class (which suffices for the whole class by monotonicity of the affine form), and confirms the climbing condition for each unresolved class. All arithmetic is exact (arbitrary-precision integers).

10.2. Machine verification of the core lemma. Lemma 4.2 is verified in Lean 4 as four theorems (`climb`, `climb_mod`, `climb_ge`, `barrier`) in the artifact `Barrier.lean`, compiled with core Lean only (no external libraries), toolchain pinned to `leanprover/lean4:v4.32.2`. `#print axioms` reports exactly `[propext, Quot.sound]`, the standard kernel axioms, and no `sorry`. We emphasize that the machine verification covers this core lemma only; the counting and rate theorems are verified by conventional proof plus the independent computations described above.

10.3. Reproducibility and data availability. All computations use exact integer (or exact rational) arithmetic. The supplementary bundle contains the certificate artifact, the Lean file with its pinned toolchain, the independent verifier, and one self-contained script per computational claim of this paper, each printing the quantity it certifies; a README lists the exact commands and expected outputs. SHA-256 hashes of the frozen artifacts:

artifact	SHA-256
<code>certificates.json</code>	d32a24e4b34eb33a0aa8f01406354ae2 2ddd65a7329b3d3309197150ad3d78fc
<code>Barrier.lean</code>	c416508cda41b0df105bae91801d70c3 7a3e2f65c0251bae1c90683492f4ec7d

11. DISCUSSION: WHAT IS AND IS NOT BLOCKED

Theorems A and A' block the descent-certificate strategy in full generality — any mixture of depths, congruence scopes of arbitrary moduli, disjunctions, adaptive stopping, and finite exceptions — and Theorems F–G block its bounded-memory Lyapunov and finite-window relaxations. It is equally important to state what is *not* blocked.

Congruence information is exhausted. By Theorem A', no repackaging of congruence conditions on the starting point — dyadic, 3-adic, or mixed — escapes the count: the certificate frontier is canonical, and its cost $2^{H(\theta)k}$ is invariant. A proof of the conjecture by descent certificates would need scopes that are not eventually periodic sets: sets defined by inequalities on orbit values, or by information of unbounded window length. The same collapse yields Corollary 6.5 — unconditionally at most $N^{0.950}$ potential counterexamples up to N — and, since the congruence necessary conditions are attained exactly, improving that exponent requires non-shadow information.

Unbounded memory and Lyapunov potentials. Theorem F excludes only per-step, bounded-memory dyadic corrections, and Theorem A' closes variable stopping for the potential $\log_2 n$ itself. Lyapunov schemes with unbounded memory, or with potentials other than $\log_2 n$ certified at variable times, are untouched — though we note that the certificate tree itself is such an unbounded-memory object, and Theorem A prices it at $2^{H(\theta)k}$ certificates per depth k .

Non-dyadic information along the orbit. Theorems F–G are 2-adic, and Theorem A' blocks 3-adic conditions only as congruence scopes on the initial point. Methods that consume 3-adic equidistribution *along the orbit of an ensemble* — in particular the Fourier-analytic route of Tao [5], which transports the initial distribution of an ensemble rather than finite windows of

a single orbit — remain outside the scope of all our obstructions. We analyze the quantitative 3-adic mixing problem in a companion paper.

The cycle route. Diophantine bounds on nontrivial cycles (linear forms in logarithms combined with verified lower bounds on cycle elements [7, 8, 9, 6]) address the periodicity half of the conjecture and are independent of everything here; the appendix records the standard bound in the form we use.

Finally, the barrier perspective suggests reading the classical density theorems not as progress toward the conjecture but as exact complexity measurements of a proof system: the certified density $1 - 2^{-(1-H(\theta))k}$ and the certificate count $2^{H(\theta)k}$ are two faces of the same entropy, and the fine structure of the frontier is governed by the continued fraction of $\log_2 3$ (Theorems C–E) — the same Diophantine data that governs the cycle route. We take this coincidence as evidence that the difficulty quantified here is intrinsic to the problem and not to one formalization.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

All code and data supporting this study — the certificate artifact, the Lean 4 proof with pinned toolchain, the independent verifier, and one self-contained exact-arithmetic script per computational claim, with a claim-to-script map and SHA-256 manifest — are openly available in the reproduction repository `collatz-barrier-repro` (<https://github.com/hikaruwakaura/collatz-barrier-repro>); a DOI-stamped archival snapshot of the exact version used here will be deposited upon acceptance. The same material is included as the supplementary bundle of this submission.

APPENDIX A. THE STANDARD CYCLE BOUND (REPRODUCTION)

For completeness we record the cycle bound used in Section 11; the method is that of Eliahou [7] with the current verification bound, and no novelty is claimed. Let a nontrivial cycle of the odd-to-odd accelerated map have odd elements $m_1, \dots, m_K$ with 2-adic valuations summing to A . Multiplying the relations $m_{j+1}2^{a_j} = 3m_j + 1$ around the cycle gives $2^A = \prod_j (3 + 1/m_j)$, hence with $M = \min_j m_j$,

$$0 < A - K \log_2 3 \leq \frac{K}{3M \ln 2}.$$

With $M > 2^{68}$ [6] the right side is below $K \cdot 2^{-69}$, forcing $A = \lceil K \log_2 3 \rceil$ and making $\|K \log_2 3\|^+$ (the distance to the integer *above*) at most $K \cdot 2^{-69}$. Running the one-sided ladder of best approximations of $\log_2 3$ (mediant steps between convergents, compared by exact integer powers 2^p vs 3^q) shows the smallest such K satisfies

$$K \geq 8,963,457,696,$$

so any nontrivial cycle has more than 2.3×10^{10} steps of the map C . Stronger bounds via m -cycle theory are known [8], and high cycles have recently been eliminated altogether [20].

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QUANTSCAPE INC., 4-11-18, MANSHON-SHIMIZUDAI, MEGURO, TOKYO, 153-0064, JAPAN
 Email address: hikaruwakaura@gmail.com